

CORE FORMULA

Pause after key exchange -> Mirror what you understood -> Check accuracy

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

After any exchange where misalignment is possible, say: 'What I understood from that is X — is that right?' Then listen.

BEST FOR

- Complex or high-stakes conversations where misunderstanding is costly
- Meetings where decisions are made verbally
- Situations where instructions or expectations are given
- Any conversation where both parties might leave with different interpretations

PHRASE BANK

Summary Checks · Confirming understanding

- "What I am taking away from this is..."
- "Let me check I have understood: you are saying..."
- "So the upshot is X — is that right?"
- "My read of this is... does that match yours?"
- "Just to confirm: we are agreed on X?"
- "I want to make sure we are aligned — my understanding is..."
- "Before we move on — I understood that to mean..."
- "Checking: the decision we just made is..."

Check Invitations · Inviting correction

- "Tell me if I have that wrong."
- "Correct me if I have missed anything."
- "Is there something in that I have missed?"
- "Where am I off?"
- "Is my read accurate?"

Quick Checks · One-line confirmations

- "So Thursday, not Friday?"
- "Short version: you want option B?"
- "So that is a yes, with conditions?"
- "Just checking — I own this now?"
- "So we ship it as is?"
- "That is a no for this quarter, right?"

Warm Mirrors · Reflecting the personal, not just the facts

- "What I am hearing is that you are exhausted, not that you want to quit — is that closer?"
- "So the hard part is not the work, it is feeling invisible while doing it?"
- "Let me make sure I have this: it is not the decision that hurt, it is how you heard about it?"
- "It sounds like you mostly need this to be heard, not fixed — am I reading that right?"
- "So underneath it all, the worry is about your dad, not the job?"
- "I want to get this right, because it matters: you are saying the trust is what broke. Is that it?"

High-Stakes Confirmations · When getting it wrong is expensive

- "Before either of us leaves this room: my understanding is we are committing to the March date. Confirm?"
- "This is the sentence I will repeat upstairs: we ship on the ninth, at current scope. Is that sentence true?"
- "I want to read that back, because we cannot afford to be misaligned on it."
- "You are asking me to sign off by Friday — before I say yes, is that precisely the ask?"
- "Let me state my understanding for the record, and you stop me at the first error."
- "We are accepting that risk with our eyes open — is that a fair statement of what we just decided?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Walking out of a meeting without confirming what was decided

Better: Just to recap before we go...

Best: Specific summary of each decision with owner and timeline, confirmed by the group.

2. Weak: Assuming you understood without checking

Better: I think I understood — let me know if not.

Best: 'My understanding is X — is that right?' Then actually listen for the correction.

3. Weak: Summarising in a way that re-argues your point

Better: Let me recap what was said.

Best: Neutral summary that reflects what was actually said, not your preferred version.

DECISION TREE

If A decision was made verbally and you want to confirm it

Summarise the decision back in one sentence.

"So we are going with X, and the deadline is Y — is that correct?"

If You are unsure what was meant

Summarise your interpretation and ask if it is right.

"I want to check I understood — my read was X. Did I get that right?"

If Someone else is unsure what was meant

Offer to summarise for them.

"Let me say back what I understood and see if that helps."

If You are at the end of a long meeting

Summarise the key decisions and owners before ending.

"Before we close — the three things we agreed on are: ..."

SCENARIOS

End of a meeting where decisions were made

Name each decision, who owns it, and by when. — "Before we close — we decided X, Y owns it, and the deadline is Z."

After receiving complex instructions

Summarise back before starting the work. — "Let me check I have that right: you need X done by Y in Z format."

After a tense conversation where alignment is uncertain

Summarise what was agreed without editorialising. — "My understanding of where we landed is... Is that yours too?"

After a long discussion where the thread was lost

Name what you think the conclusion was. — "I want to make sure we did not lose the thread — I think the decision was X."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In casual conversations where paraphrasing would feel clinical or overly formal.
- When you genuinely understood and a summary check would waste the other person's time.
- In some cultures and relationships where it signals distrust or condescension.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — End-of-meeting recap

At the end of one meeting, summarise the decisions made and confirm with the room.

Day 2 — After instructions

After receiving any instructions or requests today, summarise them back before you start.

Day 3 — Check one assumption

Identify one assumption you have made in a conversation and check it explicitly.

Day 4 — Neutral summary

Practice summarising what was said without adding your interpretation or opinion.

Day 5 — The short check

Use a one-sentence summary check in three conversations today.

Day 6 — Written summary

After a key meeting, send a short email summary of what was decided.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your checks catch any misalignments? Were any summaries corrected? Did any feel like slowing things down?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I pause at the right moment to check understanding?
- Did I summarise accurately — without adding my preferred interpretation?
- Did I explicitly invite correction?
- Did I listen to the response rather than just confirming my summary?
- Did I use this at the end of key meetings and conversations?
- Did I act on any corrections that came from the check?
- Did I avoid over-using it to the point of slowing things down?